to legitimise Britain's position in Persia still reflected a preoccupation with Russia and the supposition that it would at some point in the future try to challenge Britain's hegemony in southern Asia.

All of this not only reflected Great Game thinking, but was in contrast to the opinion of the Indian government. On 20 December 1918, Hamilton Grant had also written a memorandum further emphasising the points made in the committee meeting the previous day: that the most desirable course, from the Indian government's point of view, was to assist Persia only on a limited scale. Rather than trying to extend its political influence in Persia, the British government should be attempting to ingratiate itself better with the Persian people, who since the 1907 convention had viewed Britain as an imperial exploiter.[65] The violation of Persia's neutrality during the First World War by both British and Russian troops had angered the Persians even further so that by 1918, Britain's standing in the country was at an all time low.[66] As Chelmsford noted, 'until we have regained [the] confidence of [the] Persian people, no Persian Cabinet, however friendly, can work effectively in our interests'.[67] This idea of trying to return to a pre-1907 relationship with Persia had support from others: it had been advocated by Marling in 1917, while in January 1918 the Persian expert, E.G. Browne, had put forth his idea of an Anglo-Persian treaty based on five points, including abolishing zones of influence and allowing the Persian government to recruit advisers of whichever nationality they liked. Browne also advocated filling the Legation in Tehran with those 'who are known to be friendly and sympathetic to the Persian people'.[68]

Curzon, however, refused to acknowledge the changes which had overcome Persia in the last decade and had little time for this 'softly-softly' approach. By 30 December 1918, in another meeting of the Eastern Committee, he appeared to have entirely lost patience with the situation. The acting foreign secretary condemned the idea espoused in the previous committee meeting of leaving Persia to its own devices as 'immoral, feeble and disastrous', adding that 'if anybody imagines that this would really quit us of Persian responsibility he really must be blind'. Continuing his acerbic attack, Curzon mocked the Indian government for believing: